

"When I start something, I know the end point, but I never announce the blueprint. I work on a big canvas"

"*Makhan par lakir to sab karte hai. Karni hai to pathar par lakir karo. Kathin hai to kya hua, shuruat to kare* (It's easy to draw a line in butter, if you have to, draw one in stone. It's hard, but let's make a start). This is what I believe in"

"Being connected to the grassroots showed me how reforms improve lives. I listen to experts, formulate strategies with a mix of their advice and my ground connect"

Q. India continued to be among the fastest growing economies in 2023. What are the guiding factors that shaped your policies while dealing with the economy?
I have had a unique journey in my career in terms of experience. I have served as head of the government for 23 years [in Gujarat and the Centre] but before that for 30 years I had travelled to different parts of the country and lived among the people. I also consider myself a life-long student and believe in learning from the experiences and wisdom of others. So, in a way, I am blessed to have a strong ground connection.

Q. So what is your management style?
My approach to policy-making is slightly different. I listen to all the economists and experts and formulate my policies and strategies through a mix of their advice, my 'ground connect' and the 'lived reality' of the country. As a result of my ground connect, I have strong convictions. *Main kuchh bhi achha lage isliye nahin karta, lekin achha ho isliye karta hoon* (I don't do things because it looks good, I do it because it will do good). Growing up in poverty and having had the good fortune of being connected to people at the grassroots gave me an insight into how reforms should focus on improving the lives of the people, and not on mere headlines. It is the result of dozens of such reforms which focused on improving the lives of the people, their ease of living, their ease of doing business, that India's growth journey has picked up rapid pace. We believe in optimum utilisation of resources and outcome-oriented monitoring. We believe in achieving national goals through *jan andolans* (people's movements).

Q. Why do you pick up difficult sectors like cleanliness, sanitation and speak about them even during Independence Day addresses?
Makhan par lakir to sab karte hai. Karni hai to pathar par lakir karo. Kathin hai to kya hua, shuruat to kare (It is easy to draw a line in butter, if you have to, draw a line in stone. It is hard, but let's make a beginning). This is what I believe in, which gives me the conviction to take on difficult and uncomfortable tasks.

Q. How are you ensuring that India becomes a 5-trillion-dollar economy and the world's third largest?
Our track record speaks for itself. When I became chief minister of Gujarat in 2001, the size of its economy was around $26 billion (Rs 2.17 lakh crore). When I left Gujarat to become the prime minister, the size of Gujarat's economy had become $133.5 billion (Rs 11.1 lakh crore). And as a result of the various policies and reforms, today Gujarat's economy is around $260